court, which too remanded us in judicial custody for fifteen days. The van took us to the Ernakulam sub jail in Kacheripady. It was the first time I was getting into a jail.

The sub jail was a small facility, with five or six cells on two sides of a corridor. The jailor, a man called Joseph, was perturbed that such 'high-value accused' were brought here and he would be held responsible if something happened. The 'something,' he said later, was the probability of us escaping.

'I live a modest life out of my meagre salary,' Joseph told Sasi. 'You are big shots.' Joseph pleaded with his seniors to get us shifted to the Viyyur Central Jail, some 85 km away in Thrissur, but this night we were to stay here.

We were soon in the jail.

'We have some guests,' said Chandrasekhar, soon after we men were locked inside a cell.

'Who? Where?' Sasi asked expectantly.

'There,' Chandrasekhar said, pointing to a couple of rats scurrying across the floor.

The rats appeared to be unmindful of our presence, as if they have lived all their life in the company of human beings, which was the case.

Chandrasekhar now had a request to Sasi, 'Can you get me a drink?'

'Are you mad?' said Sasi. 'We don't have money, and even if we have, they will break our neck if we ask for a drink.'

Now Chandrasekhar and Sasi were whispering something, all I could hear that they were taking my name. I had not spoken to them or with any of the other accused ever since the arrest.

After a couple of minutes, Chandrasekhar and Sasi slowly moved towards me with a smile.

'Chandra has managed to hide Rs 500 he had got from a visitor,' said Sasi.

I kept silent.

'If we ask the policeman he would shout,' he continued. 'But you may be able to convince the warden.'